

Forget about running your business with the phone and personal meetings—here's all the information you need to set up a site that'll take a load off you

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It's a daunting proposition to develop a Web site for a home business, especially while you're juggling between all sorts of tasks to keep the business up and running. Thankfully, you now have a choice of many free tools to help you do just that—but it's not that simple. Many of these tools are built with personal sites in mind, so choosing what's right for you requires a discerning eye.

But we're getting ahead of ourselves. The first (and possibly the most important) part of setting up a new Web site is choosing a good Web host.

The Ground Up

Choosing a Web host isn't easy—you've got all those colourful proclamations of unlimited storage space and bandwidth to sift through, and the catches (there's always one) are pretty tough to pin down. Your best bet is to get plenty of reviews from people who've been using these services, preferably someone you know personally. In any case, don't cough up till you've visited the WebHosting Talk forums (www.webhostingtalk.com) and checked out what people have to say about the host you're about to

choose. Refer to the box *What you need, What it is* for what to look for when you're out Web host-hunting.

Then there's the question of *where* to host your site—India or abroad? In India, the physical proximity helps—users will be routed through fewer servers before hitting your site, so they'll get better access speeds. If you're going to cater primarily to Indian customers, we'd have unhesitatingly recommended hosting your site in India. Unfortunately, there are caveats: Web hosting here is still in its nascent stages, and the odd infrastructure issue can crop up from time to time. There's also the fact that the prices here seem criminal compared to hosts in the US. This is, of course, bound to change, but it's a chicken-and-egg situation—more people need to buy hosting for prices to fall, and vice-versa. For now, you'll get much better deals with a US host like GoDaddy (www.godaddy.com) or HostGator (www.hostgator.com). For a whole lot of features—unlimited subdomains, unlimited e-mail addresses and such (at a price, of course)—visit A Small Orange (www.asmallorange.com) or SoftLayer (www.softlayer.com). The prices are significantly higher, but you pay that price for much better reliability and service.

So you've chosen a host and are ready to register your domain name, but to your frustration find that not only is your domain of choice taken, it's taken by a squatter...

Get It Back

Cybersquatting is just what it sounds like—parking your virtual behind on a spot that should belong to someone else, and then demanding a ransom to let it go. Depending on

the URL, you might well end up in a situation where your visitor ends up at the squatter's site instead of yours. In extreme cases, you might end up in the same situation that the White House did not too long ago—the domain www.whitehouse.com was taken over by a squatter with pornographic links all over, so people who thought they were visiting the White House home page (www.whitehouse.gov) came away with a nasty shock. Court battles ensued, and today, www.whitehouse.com goes to a real Web site.

Cybersquatting is illegal, and while some are content to just choose another URL, you should file a complaint with the Asian Domain Name Dispute Resolution Centre [ADNDRC] (www.adndrc.org) to get your URL freed. The site can be daunting with all the legal jargon, though. If you don't want to do much dirty work, hire a third party like DNRecover (www.dnrecover.com). Just fill up their form and they'll give you a cost estimate in 24 hours; once you give them the go-ahead, they'll do the footwork for you, and when your domain is finally freed, you pay.

Host? Check. Domain? Check. Now it's time for content.

Choices, Choices

If you don't want to pay an overpriced Web design firm to design your site for you, don't: there are plenty of (perhaps even too many) open source CMSes for you to choose from. From our own experiences and the sheer number of new sites that are adopting them, we can tell you that you don't need to look beyond Joomla (www.joomla.org) and Drupal (www.drupal.org). Both are quite easy to administer, though if you don't have geeky leanings, you might find yourself more comfortable with Joomla's graphical control panel. Both are tremendously customisable, and you'll also have a wide choice of extensions you can install for even more functionality.

Joomla has another edge over Drupal in that it supports advertisement management right out of the box. You can create clients, associate ad banners with them and tell the system how many impressions the client has purchased for that particular banner. When you're managing banners, you can also get data on how many times the ad was clicked. You can get all this in Drupal too, but only after installing the Advertisement module.

Drupal's categorisation—called Taxonomy—takes a little while to understand; at the most basic level, it lets you put content under multiple categories, so you can file an item under "Job" and "Mumbai" at the same time. Joomla, however, supports this only after you install an extension.

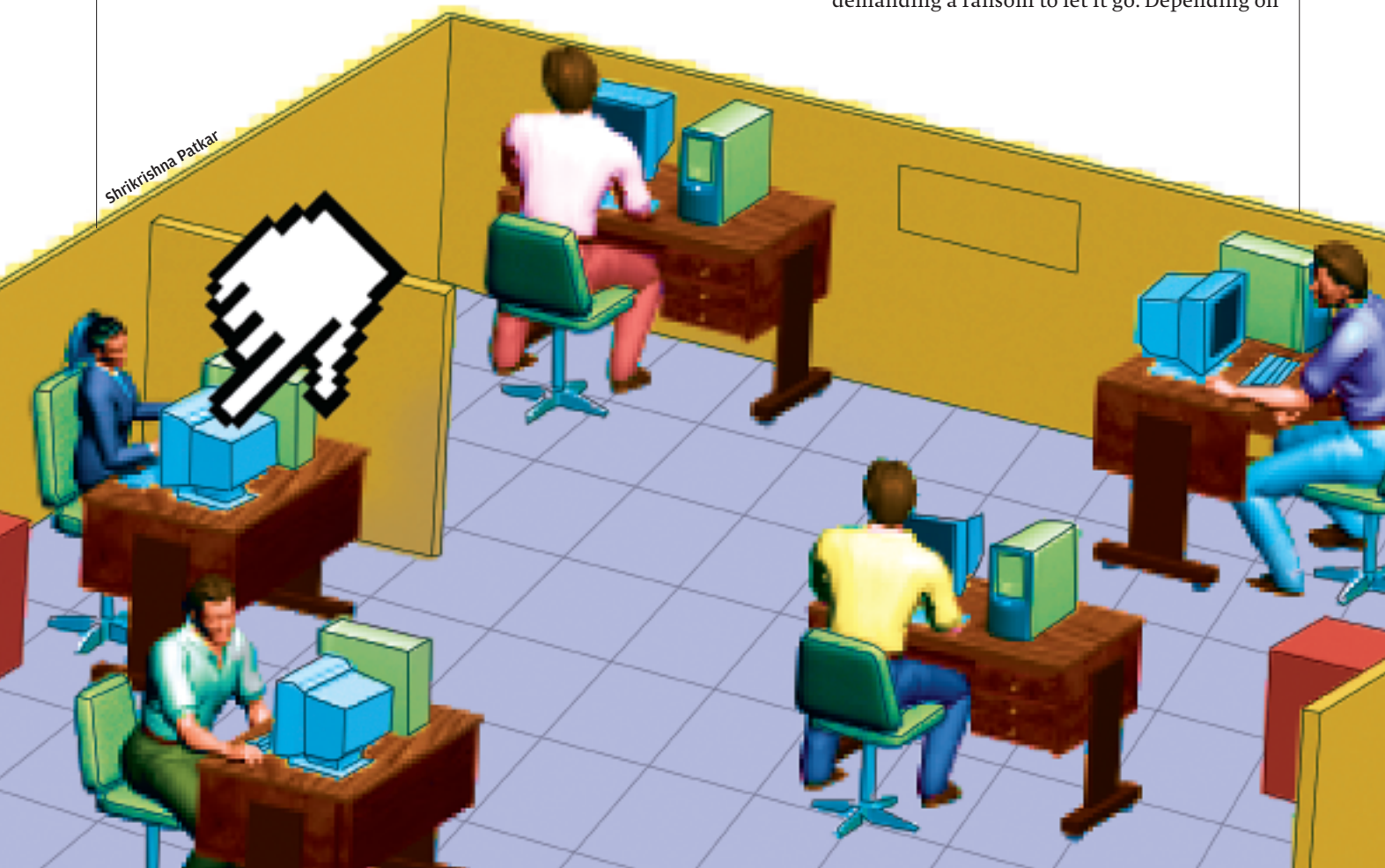
Finally, there are more themes—both free and paid—available for Joomla. This shouldn't make too much of a difference, since the option to hire a freelancer to design a theme according to your specifications as always open. Overall, if you're maintaining your site yourself, pick Joomla for its straightforward approach.

Google To The Rescue

One of Google's more interesting projects in recent times is Google Apps for Your Domain. It lets you, in short, use Google services like Gmail, Calendar and so on with your domain. So when

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